

1997

INDIA AT 50

50, AND NOT DONE

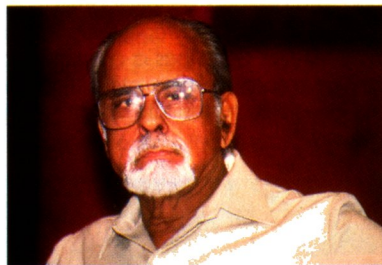
The slums are still there, but Kolkata's 'Saint of the Gutters' has gone. Eighty-five years old, 50 years of washing the sick and comforting the dying, and yet she was not ready. On September 5, her heart, which had been functioning on a pacemaker since 1989, finally gave up, too weak after a succession of heart attacks in the last few years and too tired after a lifetime of loving. She died as she lived, quietly, and as questions about her canonisation were revived, she left behind an icon that no human heart would deny.

◀◀ **REWIND**



SOUMITRA GHOSH

"BY NATURE I AM A SILENT PERSON. I WILL TALK LESS AND DELIVER MORE."



Inder Kumar Gujral

A replacement candidate for prime minister to start with and the man at the helm of India's celebration of 50 years of nationhood, Gujral found himself embroiled in problems when he took over from H.D. Deve Gowda. His efforts towards better India-Pakistan relations were lost amid the rumbling of imminent collapse at home. When parts of the Jain Commission report were first published in INDIA TODAY, implicating key DMK members in the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi, the United Front-Congress relationship got severed. The Congress withdrew support and Gujral resigned.

FIRST CUT

• Kalpana Chawla became the first Indian woman in space when she blasted off aboard NASA's space shuttle Columbia on November 19.

On her first mission as an astronaut, Chawla travelled over 6.5 million miles in 252 orbits of the earth, logging more than 375 hours in space.

◀◀ DID YOU KNOW

The Voluntary Disclosure of Income Scheme tax amnesty initiative brought Rs 33,000 crore to the government from declarations by 4,66,031 persons.